

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

THE ‘O BLOCK’ AND HOT DOGS AND THE POPE?



AP

Chicago already has a weighty international reputation, some of it less than savory, but Vatican tourists wonder if the new pontiff has the power to change public perception

By **Angie Leventis Lourgos**
Chicago Tribune

VATICAN CITY — When 15-year-old Maria Izworska from Poland hears the word Chicago, the first thing that comes to mind is “O Block,” the notoriously high-crime strip of South King Drive that’s been immortalized in rap songs and social media.

“I also think about food,” said the teen, who was sitting on the steps of St. Peter’s Square on a recent weekday while on a trip

to the Vatican. “I think about corn dogs and hot dogs.”

But now that Chicago can claim a pope, Izworska believes this papal association might improve the city’s image on the international scene.

Chicago “was already famous before the pope was elected, but it could have some influence on the reason why people would come there,” said her friend Weronika Kotarba, 15. “Now I think that when someone hears the word Chicago ... they’ll think of this stuff, but also the pope.”

During the first official week of Pope Leo XIV’s papacy, the Tribune asked Vatican City tourists from around the globe what they thought about having a Chicago-born pontiff, the only American to lead the Catholic Church in its 2,000-year history.

The teens from Poland at one point broke into song, singing the first few lyrics to “Chicago” by Michael Jackson: *I met her on the way to Chicago/Where she was all alone/And so was I so I asked her for her name.*

Turn to Pope, Page 5

Trump has new tariff threats

President vows 50% tax on goods from the EU, 25% for phones not made in the US

By **Josh Boak**
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump threatened a 50% tax Friday on all imports from the European Union as well as a 25% tariff on smartphones unless those products are made in America.

The threats, delivered over social media, reflect Trump’s ability to disrupt the global economy with a burst of typing, as well as the reality that his tariffs have yet to produce the trade deals he is seeking or the return of domestic manufacturing he has promised voters.

The Republican president said he wants to charge higher import taxes on goods from the EU, a long-standing U.S. ally, than from China, a geopolitical rival that had its tariffs cut to 30% this month so Washington and Beijing could hold negotiations.

Trump was upset by the lack of progress in trade talks with the EU, which has proposed mutually cutting tariffs to zero even as the president has publicly insisted on preserving a baseline 10% tax on most imports.

“Our discussions with them are going nowhere!” Trump posted on Truth Social. “Therefore, I am recommending a straight 50% Tariff on the European Union, starting on June 1, 2025. There is no Tariff if the product is built or manufactured in the United States.”

Speaking later in the Oval Office, Trump stressed that he was not seeking a deal with the EU and might delay the tariffs if more companies invested in the United States.

“I’m not looking for a deal,” he told reporters. “We’ve set the deal. It’s at 50%.”

Trump’s tariffs against Europe had been preceded by a threat of import

Turn to Tariffs, Page 8



AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

‘Flags In’ for the fallen

Vivian Barr, 2, places pennies on her grandfather’s headstone at Abraham Lincoln National Cemetery in Elwood during the annual “Flags In” event on Friday, ahead of Memorial Day. Vivian, whose grandfather died last year, left the coins to signify her visit to the grave. Memorial Day began as a way to remember those who died during the Civil War, but as the weekend has come to symbolize the unofficial start of summer, some veterans say its meaning has strayed too far. **Nation & World inside Business, Page 6**

Nonprofit’s greenhouse a place for growth

Lambs Farm brings therapy and training to people with developmental disabilities

By **Robert McCoppin**
Chicago Tribune

Ja’Don Banks tried growing vegetables outside his group home. He planted seeds repeatedly, and nothing came up. But this spring, with a little coaching, he’s growing hundreds of vegetable plants and flowers at a new greenhouse at Lambs Farm in Libertyville.

“Now I’ve got tomatoes in the ground and onions that I have to water,” he said. “I want to grow lettuce. I cut a potato and put five pieces in the ground, and they all came up. I’m a person that has enough patience to wait.”

Banks is part of a new horticultural program at Lambs Farm, a home for developmentally disabled adults.

The north suburban facility started in 1961 as a pet shop on State Street in downtown Chicago. It moved to its current 72-acre campus next to the Tri-State



Ja’Don Banks transplants a pepper plant in the new greenhouse at Lambs Farm in north suburban Libertyville on Thursday. For people with developmental disabilities, like Banks, gardening has been shown to have therapeutic benefits such as improving memory, cognition and social abilities. **STACEY WESCOTT/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

“He’s been hands in the dirt, and loving it. He’s a plant nerd, just like me. He was like, ‘I love this job, thank you for giving me this job.’ It’s really fulfilling to see. It’s nice for anybody to do what they love for a living. It makes it not seem like work.”

— Program manager Shelby Chellberg, on Ja’Don Banks’ gardening skills

Turn to Growth, Page 4

Smollett must donate \$50K to charity

Actor Jussie Smollett will give to a nonprofit organization to settle a lawsuit that sought reimbursement for money spent during an investigation of an infamous alleged hoax. **Chicagoland, Page 3**

Bears’ new energy comes from top

As the Bears got their first look at team activities this week at Halas Hall, players were quick to adjust to the competitive intensity of new head coach Ben Johnson. **Chicago Sports**

On trial for child’s death, Brand spars with judge

Decision to forgo licensed attorney brings peculiarity to otherwise tense setting

By **Madeline Buckley**
Chicago Tribune

Representing himself while he stands trial on murder charges, Crosetti Brand was in the middle of heatedly arguing that he was receiving an unfair trial when the judge stopped him.

“One second,” Cook County Judge Angela Petrone said. “You don’t have to call me ‘bro.’”

Brand, 39, is charged with murder, attempted murder, home invasion and aggravated domestic battery in a March 13, 2024, attack that killed 11-year-old Jayden Perkins and seriously injured his pregnant mother.

During the first two weeks of an expected three-week trial, prosecutors called more than two dozen witnesses, all together painting a searing picture of the killing at the family’s apartment in the 5900 block of North Ravenswood Avenue. After a series of harassment and threats made to Jayden’s mother, Brand barged into the home and stabbed her over and over. When Jayden tried to intervene, Brand stabbed him as well, according to prosecutors and state witnesses.

Turn to Brand, Page 5

